

Lifted Strength Club - Competitor Research & Strategy for Commercial Success

Market research for the new Longwood, FL studio, plus practical recommendations to make the website and business succeed. Companion to the design mockups and the main Project Brief.

1. The market in one paragraph

Longwood sits in Seminole County, inside the Orlando metro - a dense, competitive personal-training market. The good news: almost every competitor sells the **same generic promise** (lose weight, get toned, "transform"). Sharon's positioning - **PhD-backed strength training for mental health, explicitly anti-shame** - is genuinely differentiated and barely contested locally. The strategy below is about making that difference obvious and easy to act on.

2. Competitor landscape

Direct local competitors (private/personal training near Longwood)

Business	What they do well	Gap Sharon can exploit
Darwin Fitness (Winter Park, serves Longwood since 2012)	The local leader. 200+ 5-star reviews, private appointment-only model, strong SEO, free-trial offer.	Generic "sports performance/results" positioning. No mental-health angle, no female-founder story, no science authority at the PhD level.
One F1tness (Longwood)	Local, personal training + small-group.	Thin brand/story; competes on convenience, not specialization.
Core & More Fitness (Orlando)	Private studio, small classes, hands-on.	Not local to Longwood; no mental-health niche.
GYMGUYZ	In-home convenience, franchise polish.	Commodity service; no specialization or relationship depth.
Aggregators: Yelp, Fyt, MindBody	Where buyers browse & compare.	Sharon must have a strong presence here (reviews, photos) - these rank for "personal trainer Longwood."

Direct *niche* competitors (women / mental-health positioning)

Business	Note
Melissa King (Orlando)	Closest positioning match - coaches women through anxiety/depression. Mostly online/personal brand, not a Longwood studio.
College Park Fitness Studio	Markets women's "physical and mental" fitness + beginner confidence. Orlando, not Longwood.
FIT PRINT Orlando	Mentions strength training reducing anxiety, but as a feature - not the whole brand.

Takeaway: No one in Longwood owns "strength training for mental health." That's an open lane, and Sharon is uniquely credentialed to own it.

3. Sharon's competitive moat (lead with these)

1. **Authority that can't be faked:** a **PhD in Exercise Physiology**, 18+ years, 300+ clients, and real press (**Shape, Business Insider, Bustle, Well+Good, Greatist, Nike, Woman & Home**). Most local trainers got certified "in a weekend" - her words, and a great differentiator.
2. **A real niche, not a tagline:** strength training *for mental health*, from someone with lived experience of anxiety/depression. This attracts an underserved, loyal, referral-heavy audience.
3. **Anti-shame brand:** "No weigh-ins. No before-and-after pics." This is the opposite of every competitor and is magnetic to people who've been burned by gym culture.
4. **Two front doors:** in-studio (high-value) *and* online coaching from \$180/mo (low-barrier entry that captures people not ready/able to commit to in-person).

These three things should be visible **above the fold and repeated** - that's exactly how the mockups are built.

4. What actually drives revenue for a studio like this

Personal-training studios live or die on **(a) getting found locally, (b) converting visitors to a consult, and (c) retention/referrals**. The website's #1 job is the middle one.

Conversion levers (all built into the mockups, worth protecting in the final build): - **One primary action everywhere: "Book a Free Consultation."** Free consult removes risk and is the proven funnel for high-ticket training. Keep it the only headline CTA; don't dilute with competing buttons. - **Trust before price:** press logos + real reviews + credentials appear before the pricing section. People need to believe she's worth it *before* they see \$790-\$970/mo. - **Show the real person and the real space.** Authentic photos of Sharon coaching beat stock imagery for trust and conversion. (Already using her real photos.) - **Make price feel fair, not scary.** Anchoring with the 12-month "Best Value" tier and offering the **online tier as a low entry point** softens sticker shock. Consider also a **single paid intro session or a short "starter" package** as a stepping stone (recommendation, not currently priced). - **Reduce friction:** embedded scheduler (Acuity/Calendly) so booking happens on-site in 2 clicks, not via email tag.

5. Local SEO playbook (the highest-ROI marketing she can do)

For a local studio, **Google Business Profile + reviews** typically out-perform everything else. Priorities:

1. **Google Business Profile (do this first, it's free):** claim/create for the Longwood address. Category "**Personal Trainer**" (+ secondary "Gym/Fitness Center"). Keyword-rich description, real photos of the studio, hours, and the booking link. Complete profiles rank higher. (*My PT Hub, Institute of Personal Trainers*)
2. **Reviews are the local ranking engine.** Darwin Fitness wins partly on 200+ reviews. Build a simple habit: ask every happy client for a Google review. Aim for a steady trickle, not a burst. (*BrightLocal*)

3. **Consistent NAP** (Name, Address, Phone) identical across the site, Google, Yelp, MindBody, Fyt, Instagram. Inconsistency hurts ranking.
4. **Location landing pages & keywords:** target "personal trainer Longwood," "strength training Seminole County," "personal trainer for anxiety Orlando." The site's titles, meta, headings, and schema already do this.
5. **Her blog is a genuine SEO asset.** 20 articles on strength + mental health already rank and pull in a national audience. Migrate them carefully (see redirect plan in the Project Brief) - losing them would be a real setback. (*SpearPoint*)
6. **Get listed** on the aggregators buyers actually browse: Yelp, MindBody, Fyt - with photos and reviews.

6. Marketing channels beyond SEO (ranked by fit)

1. **Referral + review loop** - her warmest growth. Existing clients -> reviews + word of mouth. Cheapest, highest-converting.
2. **Local mental-health partnerships** - therapists, counselors, psychiatrists, and women's-health practices in Seminole County are the *perfect* referral source for "strength training for mental health." Almost no competitor is doing this. High-leverage, on-brand.
3. **Content/email** - she already writes well and has a newsletter + eBooks. Keep the lead-magnet -> email -> consult funnel; it compounds.
4. **Instagram/local community** - behind-the-scenes of the studio, client wins (no before/after - on brand), educational clips. Drives the GBP and trust.
5. **Grand-opening moment** - a launch offer or open-house event for the new Longwood location to seed first reviews and local buzz.

7. 90-day priority list (recommended)

1. **Pick a design direction** from the three mockups (or a blend).
2. **Decide the domain** (keep drsharongam.com vs. new liftedstrengthclub.com) - this gates the SEO migration.
3. **Build the chosen site** + embed scheduler + newsletter/eBook.
4. **Set up the 301 redirect map** so the existing blog ranking transfers (see Project Brief §5).
5. **Create & optimize the Google Business Profile** for Longwood, and start the review-collection habit.
6. **Outreach to 5-10 local therapists/clinics** to open a referral channel.

8. Honest risks & how the plan addresses them

Risk	Mitigation
Domain Filterer's review/SEO head start	Don't fight head-on. Win the mental health/fitness niche + therapist referrals where they're absent.
Premium price vs. budget options	Lead with authority/press/reviews before price; offer online tier + [suggested] starter session as on-ramp.
Losing existing Google ranking in the move	Disciplined 301 redirects + keep blog alive (Project Brief §5).
Self-operator bandwidth	Keep the stack simple (Gyrfangspace + Acuity) so she can run it without a developer.

Sources: *My PT Hub, SpearPoint, Institute of Personal Trainers, BrightLocal, Darwin Fitness, One F1tness, Core & More Fitness, College Park Fitness Studio, FiT PRiNT Orlando, Yelp - Longwood trainers.*